

PEACE MAKING (CONFLICT RESOLUTION) – PATHFINDER HONOR NOTES

1. What Is Peacemaking?

Peacemaking is the process of resolving conflict in a peaceful, fair, and loving way. It involves understanding the problem, listening to others, and working toward reconciliation instead of fighting. In Christian peacemaking, the goal is restored relationships and harmony, following Christ's example.

2. What Is Conflict?

Conflict is a disagreement or struggle between two or more people due to differences in opinions, needs, values, or interests.

Good Conflict

Good conflict helps people grow, understand one another, and find better solutions when handled respectfully.

Bad Conflict

Bad conflict leads to anger, broken relationships, violence, or sin when handled wrongly.

3. Causes of Conflict According to the Bible

a. Differences in Opinion (Acts 15:22–29)

People may disagree on beliefs, decisions, or methods.

b. Differences in Roles and Gifts (1 Corinthians 12:12–31)

Jealousy or misunderstanding of different abilities can cause conflict.

c. Greed and Selfishness (Genesis 13:1–12)

Competition over resources can cause disputes, as seen with Abraham and Lot.

d. Wrong Desires (James 4:1–3)

Selfish desires and pride lead to quarrels and fights.

4. The Slippery Slope of Conflict

a. Escape Responses

These avoid the problem instead of solving it.

Denial – Pretending there is no conflict

Blame Game – Accusing others

Running Away – Avoiding the situation

b. Attack Responses

These make the conflict worse.

Fighting – Verbal or physical attacks

Gossip – Talking negatively about others

Put Downs – Insults or humiliation

c. Conciliation Responses

These are healthy ways to resolve conflict.

Overlook – Forgiving minor issues

Talk It Out – Calm discussion

Negotiate – Finding a solution both sides accept

5. Reverse Role-Play (Example)

A disagreement with a friend over shared responsibilities may place you in the attack stage (arguing). Moving to conciliation by talking calmly and forgiving can restore peace.

6. Mediation and Arbitration

Mediation

A neutral person helps both sides talk and find their own solution.

Arbitration

A neutral person listens to both sides and makes a decision that others must follow.

Similarities

Both involve a third party

Both aim to resolve conflict

Differences

Mediation allows parties to decide

Arbitration gives the final decision to the arbitrator

7. Role of an Effective Mediator or Arbitrator

Listens carefully

Remains neutral

Encourages respect

Helps clarify issues

Promotes fairness and peace

8. Litigation vs Christian Conciliation

Litigation

Adversarial

Focuses on winning

Often damages relationships

Christian Conciliation

Based on forgiveness

Focuses on reconciliation

Honors God and restores peace

9. Types of Conflicts and How They Should Be Handled

Mediated – Personal disagreements

Arbitrated – Serious disputes needing authority

Litigated – Legal matters

Negotiated – Mutual agreements

10. Participating in Mediation (Role Play)

Successful mediation includes listening, respect, and compromise. Failure often comes from pride or unwillingness to cooperate.

11. Participating in Arbitration (Role Play)

Arbitration works best when parties accept the authority and decision of the arbitrator.

12. Conclusion

Peacemaking is a vital Christian skill that helps resolve conflict peacefully. By choosing conciliation over conflict, Pathfinders can become true peacemakers in their homes, schools, churches, and communities.